DigiPick of the month

Dual-Layer Shave!

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This month's winner is
Prabhu Prasad Patra
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He is the lucky winner of a Canon Pixma iP 1500 MRP: Rs. 4,495/- Redefine your printing experience with Canon Pixma

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WIN!
Send in your entry and you could win a **Canon Pixma iP 1500** just by sharing an amusing picture with a tech angle to it. The picture should be shot by you, and should not have been published anywhere earlier. E-mail your picture with the subject **'DigiPick'** and your postal address **on or before 15th of this month** to **digipick@thinkdigit.com.** One prize-winning picture will be published each month.

TOO HARSH?

Death To Virus Writers!

Sven Jaschan was recently convicted for creating the Sasser worm that wreaked havoc on the Internet last year. He was given a 21-month suspended sentence and 30 hours of community service. Critics say this is too light a sentence.

New York Times columnist John Tierney thinks it is *much* too light. In a column on July 12, he says he is almost convinced by a theory that society might benefit more from executing a virus writer than from killing a murderer.

The theory comes from economist and columnist Steven Landsburg. He published it in a column in *Slate* in late May, which he started like this: "If we execute murderers, why don't we execute the people who write computer worms? It would probably be a better investment."

Landsburg argues that if the effect of executing a murderer is deterrence, it is worth more to execute a worm writer than a killer. He estimates that the benefit of executing a murderer is roughly $100 million (Rs 436 crore), the value of the 10 murders prevented by the deterring effect of an execution.

Viruses and the like cost the world $50 billion a year, Landsburg writes. If a single execution of a virus writer could deter just one-fifth of one percent of all that malicious coding for just one year, the world would gain the same $100-million benefit we earn by executing a killer, he writes.

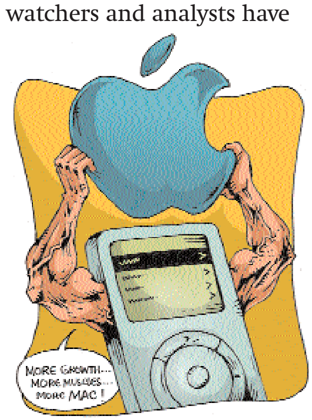
Landsburg's theory could hold water if such things could be reduced to numbers, but of course they can't. And no-one is suggesting that the death penalty is anywhere on the horizon for virus writers. But it's an idea.

THE IPOD EFFECT

More Macs In The Market

The iPod hasn't just been a product that revolutionised the portable music industry. It's exposing people to the world of Apple—and helping boost Mac sales, too!

A consumer survey by S G Cowen & Co in June lays out a convincing case for a 'halo' effect for Apple's Macs. The effect refers to the impact that one product, in this case, the iPod, is having on sales of other products, namely, Macintosh computers. Industry watchers and analysts have



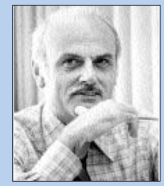
speculated on the effect for some time, but the Cowen survey actually attempted to document it by surveying over 1,400 people.

Of the 1,443 households surveyed, three per cent owned only Macintosh computers, while seven per

People Who Changed Computing

The Database Man

Edgar Codd was responsible for the creation of relational databases. While working at IBM's Almaden Research Center in the 1970s, Codd's paper called *A Relational Model of Data for Large Shared Data Banks* was path-breaking, and proposed a shift from the then-chaotic navigational database systems to a more ordered row and column system. You can read the paper at http://snipurl.com/g9pa.



Edgar F Codd

Because of Codd's work, we are able to transact online, have server scripted pages that read from databases, use our credit cards anywhere in the world and perform a myriad of other functions. Almost every task in a group or organisation needs data to be read from a database, and thanks to Codd, an airline will allow you to book tickets on any flight from anywhere in the world.

Though Codd's theory spawned a multi-billion dollar IT database industry, he never made any money off his ideas himself! No one at IBM paid heed to his theories, and by the time they realised their true potential, it was too late. IBM was beaten to the market by Lawrence J Ellison, who used Codd's theories to build a product and a start-up that is today known as Oracle.

Codd won the A M Turing Award in 1981—the highest honour a person can achieve in the field of computer science. He died of heart failure at the age of 79 in 2003.